

Archaeologies of Life and Death

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Archaeologies of Life and Death

LYNN MESKELL

Abstract

The Egyptian village of Deir el Medina, well attested in the New Kingdom as a settlement site (ca. 1550–1070 B.C.), continued to be the focus of mortuary and ritual practices from the Third Intermediate period into Late Antique and Islamic times. Data from the site are particularly rich and offer a rare opportunity to witness large-scale temporal change in mortuary practice. To date, no comprehensive syntheses have addressed the range of funerary practices in terms of specific age, status, or sex groups for various time periods. In this paper I consider the social dimension of burial at the site, drawing on statistical analyses from a range of mortuary data (tomb construction, decoration, burial goods, and bodily treatments). I suggest that the mortuary sphere shifted from a representational focus on the living world in the 18th Dynasty (ca. 1550–1295 B.C.) to an emphasis on the next world in the Ramesside period (ca. 1295–1070 B.C.). Despite the significant individual variation present in the material, it is possible to see patterns surrounding the broad themes of life and death. Finally, the substantial evidence for bodily preparations suggests that it is possible to conduct an archaeology of the body at Deir el Medina, considering cultural, social, and economic factors.*

BACKGROUND TO DEIR EL MEDINA

Deir el Medina is situated on the West Bank of modern-day Luxor, Egypt (fig. 1). It was founded during the New Kingdom to house the workmen who constructed the royal tombs, along with their families, in close proximity to the Valley of the Kings, with some measure of security. The substantial archaeological remains of Deir el Medina encompass not only the enclosed village, but also dispersed dwellings beyond the walls, silos and storage facilities, some 400 tombs scattered in various necropoleis, chapel complexes, and the Hathor temple. The first settlement was probably constructed at the outset of the 18th Dynasty, under the pharaoh Tuthmosis I (ca. 1504–1492 B.C.). It was expanded during the 19th and 20th Dynasties when the team of workmen was increased in line with the changing dimensions of the royal tombs. The official role of the village came to an end during the reign of Ramesses XI (ca. 1100–1070 B.C.), when the occupants gradually deserted the site because of civil unrest.[1] Large-scale occupation was never resumed and there are only scant traces of domestic reuse in a small number of structures contemporary with the establishment of the Christian monastery. Yet the site continued to be an important religious and mortuary locale for very different groups into Christian and Islamic times.[2]

The tombs surrounding the village were constructed in New Kingdom times, yet they contain material from the 18th Dynasty to the Christian period. The Eastern Necropolis on the hill adjacent to the village (see fig. 1) was the cemetery designated for poorer individuals in the 18th Dynasty, including many women and adolescents. Significantly, it was also the cemetery for neonates and young children at this time and there were scores of small burial pits at the lower edge of the necropolis, since lost.[3] In this cemetery there was a noticeable degree of equality in expenditure on burials of men, women, and adolescents. Although very young children were often buried more economically, they were still interred with items of jewelry and burial goods otherwise typical of adult burials.[4]

Conversely, the Western Necropolis was reserved for wealthier individuals in the 18th Dynasty, and later, in the Ramesside period, the entire community was buried there in elaborate pyramid-topped tombs with courtyards, chapels, and underground vaults, many of which were elaborately decorated. Tombs of

* This paper was prepared while I was Salvesen Research Fellow at New College, Oxford. I also want to acknowledge the support of the Institut français d'archéologie orientale in Cairo during my research and for allowing me to publish original photographs. Nigel Strudwick gave me permission to reproduce figure 6. This article is derived from my dissertation and I would like to thank those people who read and commented on the original: Robert Demarée, Ian Hodder, Barry Kemp, Dominic Montserrat, and Nigel Strudwick. Richard Parkinson provided expert assistance in the final draft stages and offered many helpful suggestions. I owe most, however, to John Baines, who read, commented on, and greatly improved the final article. I am indebted to him for his constant support and inspiration.

[1] D. Valbelle, *"Les Ouvriers de la Tombe": Deir el Médineh à l'époque ramesside* (Cairo 1985) 125.

[2] D. Montserrat and L.M. Meskell, "Mortuary Archaeology and Religious Landscape at Graeco-Roman Deir el Medina," *JEA* 84 (1997) 179–98.

[3] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1934–1935): Deuxième partie* (*FIFAO* 15, Cairo 1937).

[4] L.M. Meskell, "Dying Young: The Experience of Death at Deir el Medina," *Archaeological Review from Cambridge* 13:2 (1994) 35–45.

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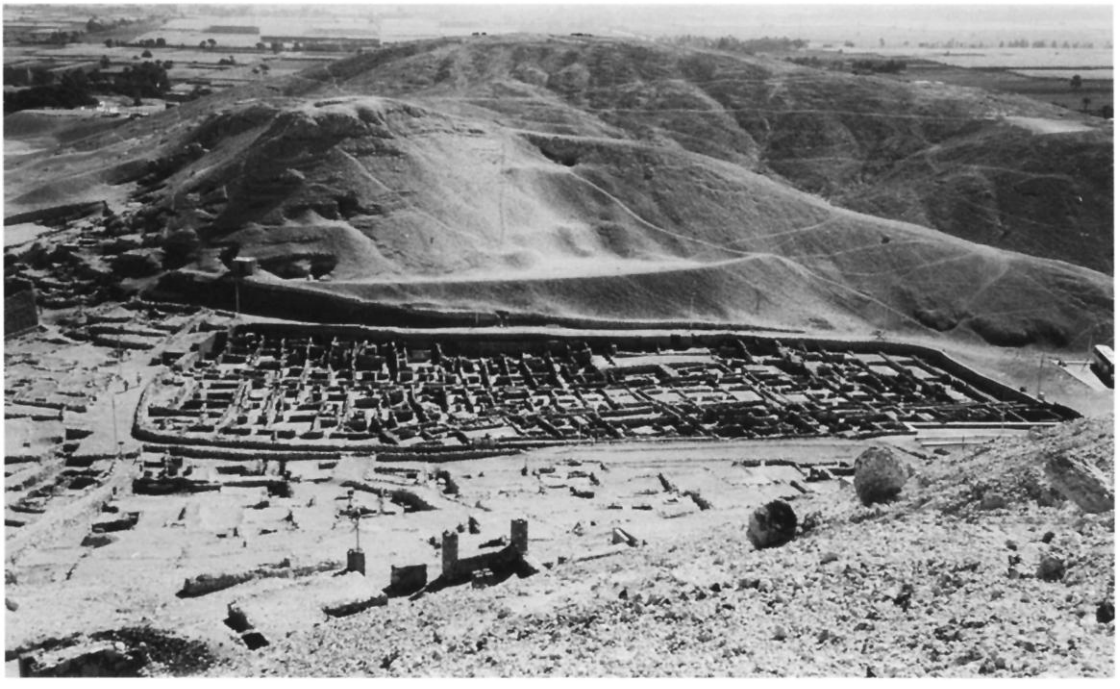


Fig. 1. View of Deir el Medina, looking east. (Photo author)

the 18th Dynasty tended to house individuals, couples, or small family groups.[5] Here there was enormous individual variation in overall expenditure, with males receiving the greatest burial wealth, women receiving considerably less, and children relegated to comparatively meager burials. Ramesside tomb complexes contained larger numbers of individuals, presumably several generations of the same family (as in the case of Sennedjem, tomb 1), and reveal slightly more balanced outlays of expense, at least between men and women. Material expenditure, however, is not always tantamount to emotional outlay and I have argued elsewhere that economic indices are often at odds with the expressions of mutual love and emotional bonding that the villagers themselves claimed in their letters, for example.[6]

LIFE AND DEATH: THE 18TH DYNASTY VS. THE RAMESSIDE PERIOD

The historical trajectory of Deir el Medina extends from the beginning of the New Kingdom to the Graeco-Roman period (ca. 332 B.C.–A.D. 395), through Late Antique times (after ca. A.D. 395), and into the Islamic period (beginning ca. A.D. 641), thus allowing inferences to be made about large-scale temporal changes in mortuary practice. I first examined the tombs and their subsequent reuse, associated assemblages, number of bodies, and treatment of the bodies themselves.[7] Recorded information for all tombs at the site was entered into a FileMaker Pro database, then imported into a statistical package (SPSS), which allowed quantification and analysis. It was possible to profile tombs of discrete dates, whether 18th Dynasty or Ramesside, and to isolate the many structures that contained goods of mixed date. This mixing was due either to later reuse or disturbance from tomb cutting.

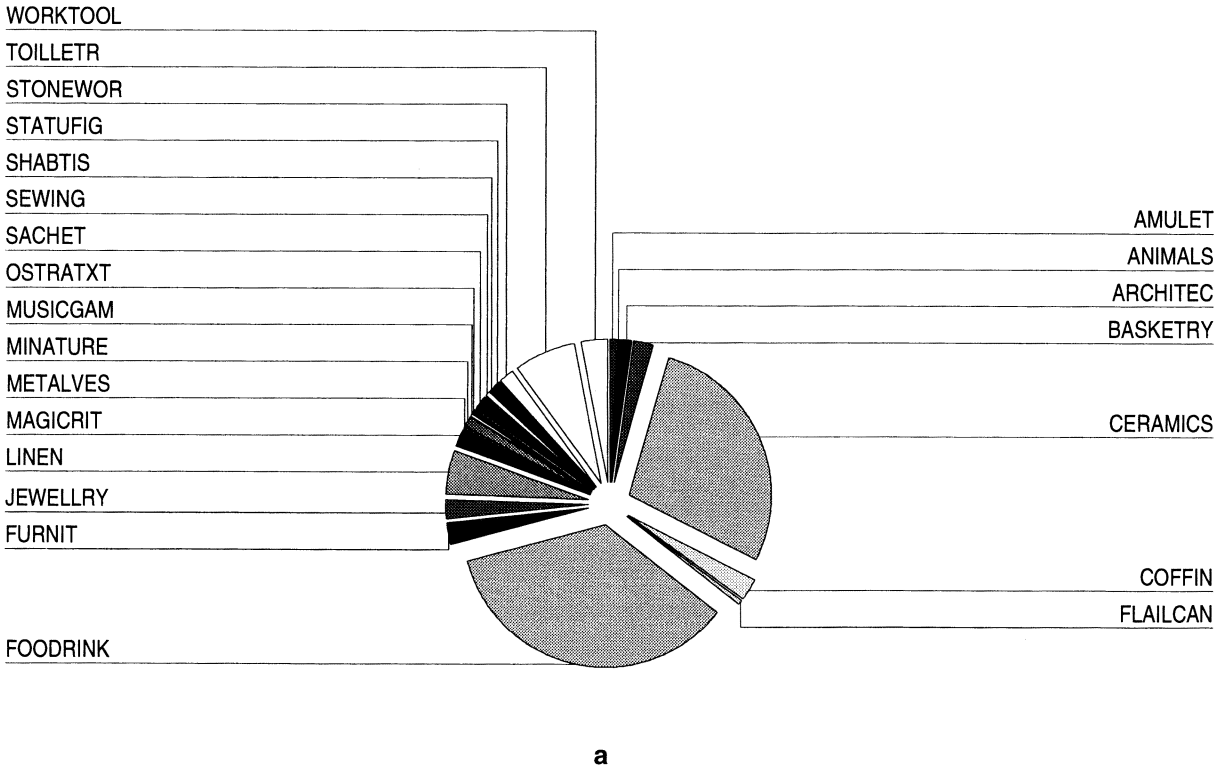
On the basis of data sets generated by SPSS, certain propositions about social dynamics can be made concerning changes from the 18th Dynasty to the Ramesside period. If one profiles the raw counts of artifacts for each period, it appears that the respective assemblages focus on quite different concepts—one centered on life, the other upon death (fig. 2).

[5] L.M. Meskell, *Egyptian Social Dynamics: The Evidence of Age, Sex and Class in Domestic and Mortuary Contexts* (Diss. Cambridge University 1997) 113; Meskell, "Intimate Archaeologies: The Case of Kha and Merit," *WorldArch* 29 (1998) 363–79.

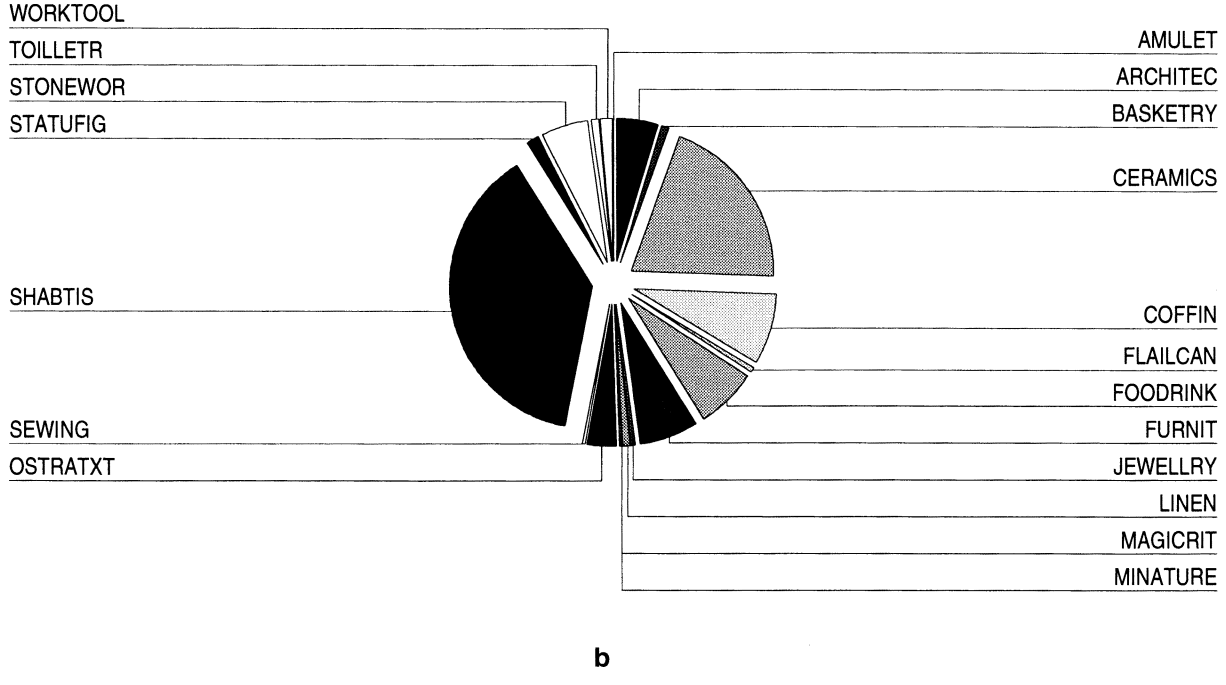
[6] Meskell 1998 (supra n. 5) 377–78.

[7] Meskell 1997 (supra n. 5) 120–27.

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a



b

Fig. 2. Relative proportions of tomb goods from a) the 18th Dynasty; and b) the Ramesside period. Charts generated by SPSS.

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This is not to say that items of material culture from daily life had no purpose in afterlife scenarios, but rather that they reflect worldly experience, whereas Ramesside goods (e.g., shabtis or canopics) were explicitly magical and ritual, serving no practical purpose in everyday contexts. There is always a degree of overlap: the change is not abrupt, but rather a gradual transition from the 18th Dynasty to the Ramesside period. Originally, Dominique Valbelle categorized the difference in tomb assemblages simply as a shift from real objects used in life (18th Dynasty) to imitations of those items (19th Dynasty), followed by a later reduction in the overall scheme (20th Dynasty).[8] In his discussion of Theban tombs, Stuart Tyson Smith went further by suggesting that personal goods and food offerings disappeared altogether in the 19th and 20th Dynasties, while items of magic increased.[9] These assertions were made prior to systematic analysis of the full range of Deir el Medina tombs or were based on intact examples, and while both these basic premises are tenable, the situation was far more complex, reflecting social and ideological developments through time.

Table 1 illustrates the general development in tomb construction, decoration, and assemblages, and the preparation of bodies at Deir el Medina (discussed below). These data refer to all tombs at Deir el Medina in both the Western and Eastern Necropoleis. I propose that this shift is better explained in ideological or cultural terms than functionalist-economic ones alone. We could be witnessing a representational focus on life and the lived experience of individuals in the 18th Dynasty, which was gradually replaced by a more visible focus on death, with a stronger emphasis on prestige, display, and familial associations. This change can be correlated directly with the construction of the tombs themselves and the numbers of people buried together in them. We know that at this time people were certainly cognizant of their direct ancestors, but this "social memory" did not generally extend back more than two generations.[10] Burials of the later dynasties also reveal a shift in focus toward the body itself, collapsing the world of the living assemblage into an elaborated body invested with specific techniques, preparations, and magical practices. If one extends the life of the village into post-New Kingdom times, it is possible to see this continued elaboration of the body at the expense of the tomb assemblage. This trend developed through the Late period and finally culminated in Graeco-Roman times.

Table 1. Mortuary Architecture and Practice through Time at Deir el Medina

18th Dynasty	19th and 20th Dynasties
Ranked cemeteries: Eastern and Western Necropoleis	One main cemetery in the Western Necropolis
More ranked burials on the basis of location, tomb construction, and assemblages	Burials showing less ranking, with more complex tombs and few simple burials
More tombs relative to time	Fewer tombs relative to time because of generational burials
Women and children often with separate, quite poor tombs	Women and children integrated into generational tombs
Tombs for individuals or couples	Generational tombs, incorporating extended families
More simple, single-vaulted tombs	Complex, more expensive tombs with many features
Tomb assemblages focusing on the world of life	Tomb assemblages focusing on the sphere of death
Tomb decoration with daily life and some afterworld scenes	Tomb decoration almost exclusively religious
Simple body treatments, very little real embalming	Elaborate body techniques, predominantly embalming
No independent chapels	Development of chapels and multifunctional structures

THE TOMB ASSEMBLAGES

Since the concept of life-oriented and death-oriented assemblages first became apparent through examination of dated tomb groups, it may prove expedient to profile the artifacts in an effort to demonstrate this change of focus from the living world to the experience of death and the afterlife. The con-

[8] Valbelle (supra n. 1).

[9] S.T. Smith, "Intact Tombs of the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Dynasties from Thebes and the New Kingdom Burial System," *MDIK* 48 (1992) 220.

[10] A.G. McDowell, "Awareness of the Past in Deir el-Medina," in R.J. Demarée and A. Egberts eds., *Village Voices* (Leiden 1992) 106.

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tents of 132 discrete 18th Dynasty tombs (107 from the Western Necropolis and 25 from the Eastern Necropolis) and 55 tombs of the 19th–20th Dynasties (all Western Necropolis) were analyzed. No mixed assemblages with varying dates were considered. Because of the initial recording and dating, it is always possible that items of a later period may have been inadvertently included. It seems clear, however, that the constellation of goods most commonly present in 18th Dynasty assemblages revolved around the life of the tomb owner and the daily activities in which he or she may have been involved.[11] In the case of men, there is a wide variety of work equipment, such as hammers, adzes, scales, palettes, scribal equipment, cubits, and weights. The tomb of Kha (8) is a clear example; one of the boxes discovered in his tomb is even labeled "workbox."[12] Also included in his tomb were blocks of gypsum, which again must relate to his duties as chief workman and architect. The tombs also contained objects used for more relaxed pursuits, such as musical instruments and gaming boards. Their earthly function, however, does not detract from their specific purpose in the afterlife.[13] Clothing and toilet items, e.g., cosmetics including galena, kohl jars, unguents, perfume jars, razors, pins, and combs, featured heavily for both men and women. Generally speaking, there appears to be a more varied array of local and foreign ceramics and higher percentages of models of food and ceramic miniatures in the 18th Dynasty tombs.[14] The miniatures might have initiated a trend toward the small magical imitations we see later in the 19th Dynasty—the obvious example being shabtis.[15] Only about 20 shabtis were excavated in situ for the entire 18th Dynasty, whereas there are over 600 for the 19th and 20th Dynasties combined. If one considers all shabtis that postdate the 18th Dynasty, they number well into the thousands. The earlier Ramesside figure is a conservative estimate from secure tomb contexts, though given the ideal of 365 shabtis for an individual burial, the overall number must have been significantly higher. Another notable difference is that 18th Dynasty shabtis tend to be sculpted individual pieces, more akin to small statuettes than mass-produced figures totaling the necessary 365—one for every day of the year.

Other items that figure heavily in the 18th Dynasty and are directly related to the living sphere are foodstuffs and flowers. Meat, fowl, vegetables, fruits, nuts, grains, spices, breads, cakes, and biscuits appear in great variety. This does not imply that such items were without ritual or religious function, but rather that they directly reflect domestic contexts. Take again the case of Kha and Merit in tomb 8 (fig. 3). There was an amazing array of bread types; amphoras of grain, wine, and preserved meats; bowls of vegetable paste; seasoned vegetables; dates, grapes, and other fruit; a box of salt; bunches of garlic; baskets of juniper and cumin; sacks of dom nuts; and even a basket of dung for the fire.[16] Items such as these not only mirror earthly existence, but ensure sustenance in the next life for the individual as well as for his or her *ka*. Aspects of the divisible self also had to be sustained in the next life.[17] Goods from daily life decrease significantly in the later dynasties: the substantial emphasis on the living, sustaining aspect of the afterlife was gradually replaced by ritual and magical objects derived specifically from the mortuary sphere. One could argue that the 18th Dynasty assemblages represent a cheaper alternative to specially made tomb goods, but this is simplistic and not necessarily borne out by the data, while also failing to account for the ideological component. Purely financial reasons cannot be posited for the changing character of the assemblages. Moreover, one can also see the beginnings of the shift toward greater emphasis on magical practices in the 18th Dynasty. At that time tomb assemblages contained scented earth, colored stones, lime powder, parts of animals (e.g., gazelle hooves), and idiosyncratic objects such as miniature sarcophagi with wrapped winged insects, all suggestive of magical practice.[18] The inclusion of magico-ritual elements reached its apex, however, in subsequent periods.[19]

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[11] Meskell 1998 (supra n. 5) 114.

[12] Smith (supra n. 9) 208.

[13] H. Milde, "It's All in the Game: The Development of an Ancient Egyptian Illusion," in J.H. Kamstra, H. Milde, and K. Wagtendonk eds., *Funerary Symbols and Religion* (Kampen 1989) 89–95.

[14] Contra Valbelle (supra n. 1).

[15] The following figures would be significantly increased if they were to include examples now in museum collections (Rob Demarée, personal communication, 1996).

[16] S.T. Smith, "They Did Take It with Them: Requirements for the Afterlife Evidenced from Intact New Kingdom Tombs at Thebes," *KMT* 2:3 (1991) 28–45, 67.

[17] J. Baines and P. Lacovara, "Death, the Dead and Burial in Ancient Egyptian Society," paper delivered at the American Research Center in Egypt, New York, 1996; L.M. Meskell, "The Egyptian Ways of Death," in M. Chesson ed., *Social Memory, Identity and Death: Intradisciplinary Perspectives on Mortuary Rituals* (Washington, D.C., forthcoming).

[18] Meskell 1997 (supra n. 5) 149–50.

[19] G. Pinch, *Magic in Ancient Egypt* (London 1994).

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Fig. 3. Plates of food from the tomb of Kha and Merit (8), Deir el Medina, now in the Turin Museum. (Photo author)

Valbelle claimed a significant general decline in the total number of 20th Dynasty goods.[20] The 19th and 20th Dynasties, however, witness a dramatic development of ritual paraphernalia clustered around the dead body and the dead individual in the afterlife. In Ramesside times there is an exponential increase in shabtis, now numbering into the thousands and made from a variety of materials. Paralleling this are increases in shabti boxes, libation vessels, stone vases, statuary, canopic jars, and limestone stelae, all of which had specific connotations for the individual in death. In terms of the burial itself, increases are noted in funerary sledges, anthropomorphic coffins, stone coffins, cartonnage, mummy decorations, and funerary amulets, suggesting that the death assemblage had become more fully articulated and specialized. Bodies too become more highly elaborated, with increasing numbers of amulets and pectorals incorporated into the wrappings. Magical texts are found more often as well as the expensive Books of the Dead, which were rare in 18th Dynasty tombs of even the very wealthy. Bodies were also treated differently in the Ramesside period than earlier. More emphasis was given to the removal and preservation of organs in canopic jars, and eviscerated bodies were stuffed with natron sachets to ensure their survival into the afterworld. The body was invested with time-consuming embalming procedures and the overall treatment of the body was more labored and intricate. The body in death becomes an important focus, which represents a significant shift from 18th Dynasty practices. This material shift accords well with the textual data from the Ramesside period dealing with bodies and selves in the transitional phase of death, and beyond into afterlife, which I discuss below.

Even seemingly mundane categories of material culture took on a new funerary theme, as in the case of some groups of Ramesside ceramics. One group that requires closer examination is the postfired painted polychrome amphoras (fig. 4) that are synonymous with the site and have been recorded in Western Necropolis tombs 1, 10, 339, 357, 359, 360, 1115, 1164, 1165, and 1322–1323.[21] This blue-painted pottery was characterized by floral garland motifs, which reappear in Ramesside temples, tombs, shrines, ostraca, etc., and had a particular significance for the villagers. Martha Bell concluded that there were close connections between Ramesside tomb decoration, funerary objects, and the Deir el Medina vases: the workmen themselves were probably responsible for the creation of these decorated

[20] Valbelle (supra n. 1).

[21] M.R. Bell, "Regional Variation in Polychrome Pottery of the 19th Dynasty," *Cahiers de la céramique égyptienne* 1 (1987) 49–76.

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Fig. 4. Ramesside ceramics from Deir el Medina. (Photo courtesy Institut français d'archéologie orientale, Cairo)

ceramics.[22] Many appear never to have been used and were thus created specifically for the tomb. This highly specialized product appeared only in small numbers at Gurob, but nowhere else, suggesting that the ceramics were produced at Deir el Medina and exported from there. Taken together, the evidence suggests that these vessels were used in ritual, having special meaning for the Deir el Medina community. The predominance of the floral, specifically lotus, motif had connotations of rebirth and rejuvenation: the vessel shape itself is reminiscent of the hieroglyph for heart. They could be associated with the funerary banquet or with the Festival of the Wadi,[23] similarly connoting the theme of rebirth. Whether the festival link is correct or the vessels were simply employed in local ritual or cult, Bell states that they were not used for everyday activities, thus solidifying the argument presented here that the Ramesside material is characterized by a shift toward the ritual and mortuary sphere.

From the 19th Dynasty onward, expensive tomb decoration and tomb goods suggest a desire for prestigious, special-purpose items, directed toward representation and display. Such goods would have acted as visible markers of status and symbolic capital for the tomb owner. As Kathryn Bard suggests in her own mortuary studies, the purpose "of such status display of many sumptuary goods in burials may have been to define social (and political?) roles for living descendants, as well as being a form of payment by those socially obligated to the deceased."[24] This development is illustrated by a sharp increase in inscribed limestone goods: vases, libation vessels, statuary, stelae, stone lintels, wall fragments, and pyramidions. Each of these items entailed time-consuming manufacture, a representational element highlighting the male tomb owner, resulting in an expensive, durable, and elaborate overall project. The beginnings of this trend no doubt can be traced to the 18th Dynasty, when tombs presumably had limestone stelae or small monuments as tomb markers, though one can only reconstruct these from the numerous limestone fragments on the surface and within disturbed tombs. Monumental elements such as these

[22] Bell (supra n. 21) 54–55.

[23] Bell (supra n. 21) 56–57, describes the festival as one of rebirth where celebrations consisted of processions and excessive banqueting. Large amounts of food and intoxicants were consumed (some in elaborate vessels) and upon arrival, guests were presented with floral collars. The high point was the presentation of Amun himself, ritually symbolizing regeneration. Floral collars, such as those from the tomb of Tutankhamun and some villagers at Deir el Medina, were known as "collars of justification" (56–57). They were strictly associated with the deceased.

[24] K.A. Bard, *From Farmers to Pharaohs: Mortuary Evidence for the Rise of Social Complexity in Egypt* (Sheffield 1994) 112–13.

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Fig. 5. The tomb of Nw and Nakhtmin (291) in the Western Necropolis at Deir el Medina. (Photo author)

focused on the dead individual or couple and on the sphere of death. I am not implying that funerary practices of the 18th Dynasty did not emphasize the afterlife, but rather that this representational specificity culminated in the Ramesside period. This reflected a period of reconciliation and consolidation, possibly prompted by the ideological upheavals of the intervening Amarna period.

TOMB STRUCTURE AND DECORATION

The next consideration is structural change in tomb architecture, which parallels the conceptual developments in the tomb assemblages at each stage. Single-vaulted tombs predominate in the 18th Dynasty (72%), though multiple-vaulted structures did exist, as did tombs with a superstructure. Pyramid-complex tombs may have been initiated at Deir el Medina in the mid-18th Dynasty by Kha (8) or by one of his contemporaries, but most were built toward the end of the 18th Dynasty, like those of Smen (1089), Nakhy (1138), and May (338). One interesting case is the tomb complex of Nw and Nakhtmin (291), which dates to post-Amarna times at the end of the 18th Dynasty (fig. 5). Here we see the increasing trend toward a complex generational structure incorporating the burials of father and son, as well as other presumably related individuals. This practice developed rapidly in the 19th Dynasty and continued into the 20th Dynasty. Ramesside single-vaulted tombs are in the minority, constituting 19% of tombs dated specifically to this period. The standard Ramesside burial type at Deir el Medina is the tomb complex with its multiple vaults, chapel, courtyard, and pyramidion (table 2).

On a more general level, the design and decoration of Theban tombs were also significant in the shift from the 18th Dynasty to the Ramesside period and from the living world to the sphere of death that we witness at Deir el Medina. Though the interpretations proffered by N. Davies and Nigel Strudwick, outlined below, pertain to Theban tombs in general, both analyses include data from Deir el Medina and are relevant to this discussion. Davies recorded an increase of mortuary chapel depictions in tomb paintings from the end of the 18th Dynasty onward.[25] She

Table 2. 19th and 20th Dynasty Tomb Construction

Tomb Type	Number of Tombs
Single-vaulted tomb	20
Multiple-vaulted tomb	19
Multiple-vaulted tomb with chapel	27
Multiple-vaulted tomb with chapel, courtyard, and pyramidion	38

[25] N.M. Davies, "Some Representations of Tombs from the Theban Necropolis," *JEA* 24 (1938) 25.

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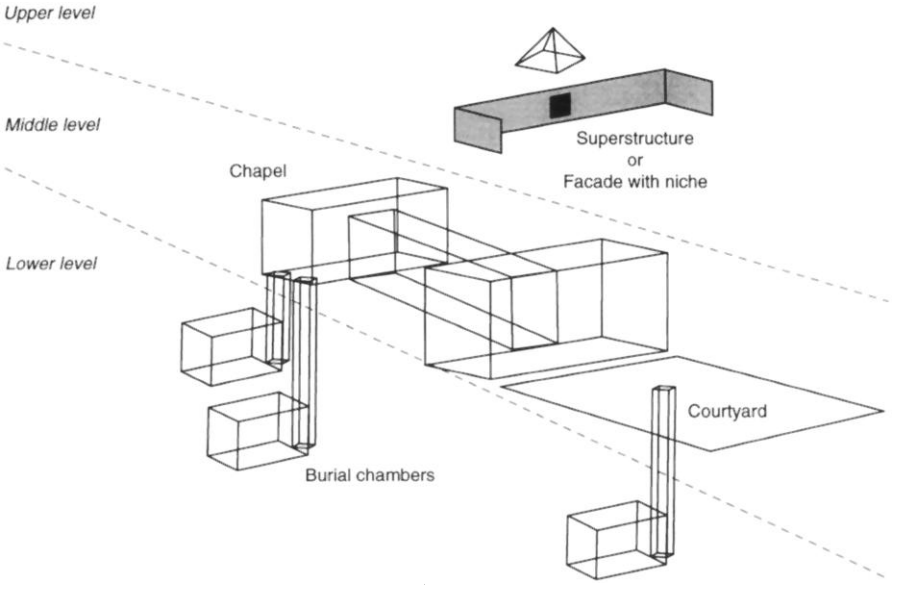


Fig. 6. Schematic diagram of the pyramid tomb complex. (Courtesy N. Strudwick)

also discussed Bruyère's reconstruction of a tomb chapel at Deir el Medina, commenting that the archaeological evidence seems to complement the pictorial data. Toward the end of the 18th Dynasty, the pyramid tomb appeared with a string of funerary cones below the cornice. The fragments discovered at Deir el Medina suggest that such structures were common at the site, though primarily in the 19th and 20th Dynasties. Davies noted that pyramidia were found at Deir el Medina and bear representations of a human figure adoring solar deities. A small niche halfway down the pyramid often contained a kneeling figure in relief behind a stele, as if a man were holding it and looking out from the pyramid at the spectator.[26]

To summarize Strudwick's argument, the break with 18th Dynasty Theban tomb construction was marked by a more rigid organization of superstructure, chapel, and substructure, each with its own symbolic purpose (fig. 6).[27] The superstructure, often a small pyramid, embodied the solar aspect of the tomb, developing from a sporadic use in the 18th Dynasty of varying types of superstructures. The 19th Dynasty chapel took on aspects of a temple to the deceased and the gods worshipped in that sphere, paralleling the shift toward the world of the dead. In wealthier Theban tombs the substructure had the aim of representing the next world. Decorative features similarly demonstrated this shift in sensibilities. Pre-Ramesside tombs feature "scenes of daily life" more regularly, whereas they decreased after the reign of Ramesses II. Scenes and texts of an explicitly religious or funerary nature predominated in the Ramesside period, turning the chapel into a monument not unlike the mortuary temple and concerned with the passage of the deceased into the next world, for example, through representation of chapters of the Book of the Dead.[28] The depiction of burial scenes on tomb walls also increased sharply (fig. 7). The Ramesside project diverges from its predecessor in its explicit focus on the shift from life into death and passing into the afterworld. Venerating the gods to ensure this passage thus became a focal point of tomb decoration. The 18th Dynasty scenes of life may have represented the desire to extend the world of the living into the hereafter, whereas from the 19th Dynasty onward a clearer concern was expressed for the experience of death and articulation of the next world.

Strudwick suggests that this change (or reduction) in expression may stem from the religious upheaval in the Amarna period at the end of the 18th Dynasty, and that "within perhaps twenty to twenty-five years of the death of Akhenaten, the world of the Rames-

[26] Davies (supra n. 25) 26.

[27] N. Strudwick, "Change and Continuity at Thebes: The Private Tomb after Akhenaten," in C. Eyre, A. Leahy, and L.M. Leahy eds., *The Unbroken Reed: Studies in the Culture and Heritage of Ancient Egypt, in Honour of A.F. Shore* (London 1994) 321–36.

[28] Strudwick (supra n. 27) 324.

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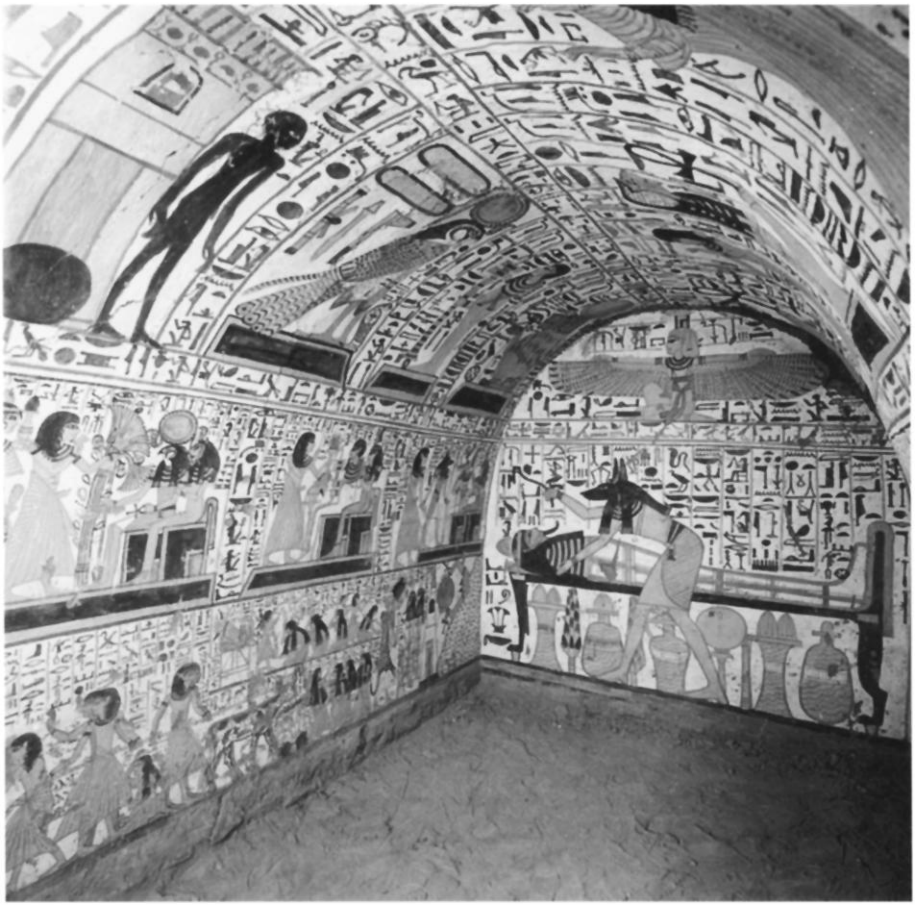


Fig. 7. Images of the deceased Nebenmaat (219) from his tomb in the Western Necropolis, Deir el Medina. (Photo courtesy Institut français d'archéologie orientale, Cairo)

side tomb had evolved."[29] This factor could indeed explain the shift in religious ideology after a period when the traditional pantheon of gods was suppressed and one deity alone, the Aten, was allowed to be venerated. The Aten did not embrace the traditional deities concerned with death and the afterlife and was far removed from individual access. Stephen Quirke has commented that "at a stroke . . . the supernatural plane is converted from a populous home of innumerable gods and goddesses into the empty prospect of a single celestial being moving visible across the sky, devoid of any company or echo save the presence of the king on earth."[30] After this short-lived upheaval with its increased focus on the "living" element of religious worship rather than the afterlife per se, an enhanced focus on traditional deities connected with success in the afterworld would seem to be appropriate.

Amarna religion is often described as iconoclastic. Jan Assmann proposes that this radical suppression of iconic polytheism unleashed a reactionary flood of images in the Ramesside period that continued to increase steadily until the 21st Dynasty.[31] The remoteness, uniqueness, and inaccessibility of Aten worship must have been anathema for Egyptians. Since *life* was the central focus of Amarna theology, the mortuary element was largely ignored. In Amarna theology the underworld journey of the god was replaced by a description of absence of life and a cosmic *death-strickenness*. Hence there was no way to amalgamate the traditional concept of the underworld journey with Amarna theology;[32] this lack presumably had serious implications for individual aspirations for the afterlife. The world of the dead was basically unimportant.[33] So much moral discourse and social competition had traditionally been conducted

[29] Strudwick (supra n. 27) 330.

[30] S. Quirke, *Hieroglyphs and the Afterlife in Ancient Egypt* (London 1996) 123.

[31] J. Assmann, *Egyptian Solar Religion in the New Kingdom* (London 1995) 66.

[32] Assmann (supra n. 31) 101, 175.

[33] J. Baines, "Society, Morality and Religious Practice," in B.E. Shafer ed., *Religion in Ancient Egypt* (London 1991) 190.

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in terms of the next life that a whole dimension of meaning, which was integral for this life and the next, seems to have been lost.[34] The subsequent Ramesside period, with its emphasis on expressions of personal piety, complementarity, and eclecticism has been perceived by some commentators as a reaction to the narrow focus of the Amarna theology. This shift in emphasis might also have affected concepts of the body and the creation of images since the Ramesside religious system was bound in a three-tiered system, as Assmann states:

> The cosmology of the Ramesside Amun theology . . . gave rise to the cosmogonic concept that appropriates the terminology of traditional solar theology, the idea of the ba and corpse, to express something quite new by adding a third component: the image. . . . By inhabiting and filling the world as ba, image and body (viz. the three aspects of his person), he personifies the cosmos.[35]

According to Assmann, in the Ramesside period the individual takes the god into his or her very heart and body.[36] The Ramesside experience was one of an unstable and unintelligible world, which did not inspire confidence: only the god assumed a stabilizing role. Assmann refers to this as "the god of the individual." The Ramesside period is marked by a new concern with personal piety. This phenomenon is not limited to material culture or specific classes, but rather pervades the whole of Ramesside culture, from its religious institutions and monuments, to art and literature. The move began in the 18th Dynasty, yet only came to prominence after the collapse of Amarna religion.[37] These factors combined may have prompted the increasing focus on the mortuary sphere, and more specifically, care of the bodily self in death. For a time of great personal religiosity, the Ramesside period was characterized by corruption, internal strife, and social insecurity. The aftermath of the shattered Amarna episode may have left residual feelings of insecurity among the populace, and a loss of faith in the position of the king as mediator between individuals and their gods. Although Assmann posits religious sentiments as paramount, surely this move from a mortuary experience based around the living world to that of the world of death reflects and incorporates other factors of social change.

The dramatic scenario proposed by Assmann has been reassessed by John Baines, who sees this change in terms of representation rather than reality.[38] He reasonably argues that piety existed before Akhenaten's reign but that its display was restricted: the Amarna episode enabled change in the styles of representation. Changes in decorum in the Ramesside period allowed a substantial loosening of earlier practices. Moreover, earlier practices assumed other, often less durable, forms than the traditional Ramesside phenomena of inscribed stelae and tomb representations.[39] Baines posits two central developments. The first occurred in the 18th Dynasty when individuals began depicting pharaohs in direct form on their own nonroyal monuments, as well as deities in some contexts. The second occurred after the Amarna period when people began displaying scenes of adoration of deities in the main areas of private tombs. This trend is more in keeping with the notion of democratization, which we also find with burial practices and bodily treatment. Perhaps it was the arena of display and modes of representation that radically changed. As Baines notes, "individuals and bodies of people in different periods may be more or less religious and more or less overt in their display of religion; periods also have distinctive styles."[40] He rightly questions the vigor of Assmann's views on the centrality of the Amarna experience—was it a peak of activity or of expression? The material patterns observable at Deir el Medina can certainly be accommodated within this more moderate view. Since we cannot tap into ancient *mentalité*, we may be on safer ground to speak of changes in representation and style.

ELABORATION OF THE BODY AT DEIR EL MEDINA

> Normal disposal is by inhumement, entombment, inurnment, or immurement, but many people just lately prefer insarcophagusment. That is *very* individual.
>
> Evelyn Waugh, *The Loved One*

In terms of individuals and mortuary practices, the Ramesside period at Deir el Medina marks a shift from the interment of individuals, couples, or restricted nuclear families, which was typical of the 18th Dynasty, to the inclusion of many individuals and extended families in a single tomb. The burials of young children, adolescents, and single people appear to be amalgamated into these larger tomb

[34] Baines (supra n. 33) 190.

[35] Assmann (supra n. 31) 174–77.

[36] Assmann (supra n. 31) 195.

[37] J. Assmann, "State and Religion in the New Kingdom," in W.K. Simpson ed., *Religion and Philosophy in Ancient Egypt* (Yale Egyptological Series 3, New Haven 1989) 55–88.

[38] J. Baines, "New Kingdom Letters and Religious Practice," paper presented at the Seventh International Congress of Egyptology, Cambridge, 3–9 September 1995.

[39] On votive offerings, see G. Pinch, *Votive Offerings to Hathor* (Oxford 1993).

[40] Baines (supra n. 38).

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structures; this interpretation is supported by the negligible numbers of poorer Eastern Necropolis tombs that can be securely dated later than the 18th Dynasty. The generational tombs in the Western Necropolis reflect an increasing awareness of the relatedness of individuals, who share a common destiny in this life and the next. This shift toward lineage-based burial might represent a different type of social awareness and responsibility, or a material response to economic pressure, i.e., limited time and resources, or perhaps an increased desire to enhance one's opportunities in living contexts through associations with dead, though related, members of the community. This last point is relevant to the competitive nature of employment in this specific village. Jaroslav Černý's translation of O Cairo 800, 1–2 records a list of items used in a failed attempt by a father to bribe chief workmen into promoting his son.[41] Various reasons, or a combination of these, can therefore be postulated for this significant shift in mortuary practice, which operated on both material and social levels.

The treatment of individual bodies parallels this Ramesside trend toward concentration on the afterworld. Work on the range of bodily treatments at the site has been limited, possibly due to the early date of the excavation and the difficulties of actually tracing the human remains recovered. Bruyère did go into some detail in his descriptions of specific bodies, usually those that were well preserved and still intact, rather than the masses of dismembered bodies he encountered in many of the reused tombs. For the most part, bodies of the 18th Dynasty were treated differently from those of the 19th and 20th Dynasties. In the earlier period, bodies were often simply wrapped rather than embalmed in natron and generally did not have the viscera removed and preserved separately. These earlier bodily practices were somewhat different from the canonical procedures we envisage for Egyptian mummies. Our image of the traditional practices surrounding death and burial comes largely from documentary data, often dating from later times. The materiality of bodies at Deir el Medina in the 18th Dynasty challenges this normative picture.

Bodily practices changed markedly after the Amarna period, when we see a rapid increase in complex mummification procedures. Since these processes were known in the 18th Dynasty, it is clear that greater care of the body in the context of death was a matter of choice. Smith's conclusions concerning bodily treatment pertain only to a small number of individuals and may not be representative of the site.[42] He concludes correctly that removal of the internal organs (the traditional characteristic of embalming in Egypt) was by no means universal and that at least two styles of mummification practice were available. He then goes on to correlate these directly with status. This correlation cannot be substantiated, since two of the wealthiest 18th Dynasty burials, those of Kha and Merit (tomb 8) and Sennefer and Nefertiry (tomb 1159A), show no evidence of evisceration but simply have wrapped bodies.[43] Embalming was extremely rare in this period at Deir el Medina. An exception was found in the intact tomb 1408 from the Western Necropolis, which contained a single male individual (40–50 years old) whose torso was stuffed with rags, suggestive of organ removal. Notably, he had 25 or more layers of wrappings with various items placed within those layers. The burial assemblage was not prestigious and did not resemble that of Kha or Sennefer, so it would seem to have less association with wealth or status than with individual preference. We should consider that personal intention, difference, and variability were operative in the treatment of bodies in the funerary context.

The trend toward a more elaborated focus on the body increased in the 19th Dynasty and continued to do so until the end of the Graeco-Roman period. Most individuals in the 19th and 20th Dynasties opted for some form of natron or resinous treatment as well as the removal of internal organs. This is marked upon the bodies themselves, and also in the paraphernalia of burial associated with embalming and mummification procedures. Ramesside ostraca suggest that wrapping of a body might take place in the village over a day or so, as in the cases of the woman Theny (O Cairo 25554) and the man Harmose (O DeM 126).[44] Elaborate preparations were deemed necessary to preserve the integrity of the body in the afterworld and during the journey there. This situation correlates with the picture of the body in death that can be derived from the texts.[45] Concepts of embodiment changed with social and cultural influences throughout that time. There were

[41] J. Černý, *A Community of Workmen at Thebes in the Ramesside Period* (Cairo 1973) 116.

[42] Smith (supra n. 9) 199.

[43] Meskell 1997 (supra n. 5) 124.

[44] J.J. Janssen and P.W. Pestman, "Burial and Inheritance in the Community of the Necropolis Workmen at Thebes," *JESHO* 11 (1968) 140.

[45] Meskell (supra n. 17).

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major periods of upheaval coupled with the creation of hybrid cultures under Greek and Roman conquests. These new groups had very different views about the enculturated body and the body in death. Patterns may be discerned in terms of temporal change and on the basis of sex, age, and class.

BODILY HISTORIES

The general pattern of elaboration outlined above can now be tested against the specific cemeteries and individual tombs of Deir el Medina—throughout the New Kingdom and beyond. Many Egyptologists would claim that the site is unrepresentative and its data unusable, yet it is one of the few coherent data sets we possess for the pharaonic period. Moreover, the entire issue of what constitutes a representative sample is open to question.[46]

A study of 25 well documented tombs from various sectors of the Deir el Medina cemeteries allows certain propositions to be made about the treatment and elaboration of mummified bodies throughout the New Kingdom. Overall, the preparation of bodies was less elaborate than one would expect, varying widely according to factors such as age, sex, and socioeconomic group. In the Eastern Necropolis children were often buried in rags or a single cloth, without embalming, and were subsequently reduced to a skeletal state (e.g., tombs 1372, 1374, and 1375).[47] In 1372, however, one girl had three layers of wrappings and in 1382 another girl had five layers, so that treatment was individual and variable rather than standardized. Older individuals of both sexes rarely display any organ removal, but many bodies were shaven and hairless, as in the 18th Dynasty tombs 1370, 1379, and 1388.[48] As for wrappings and shrouds, individuals often had eight or nine layers, or as many as 15; the number varied significantly between occupants of a single tomb. Bruyère commented that these poorer individuals were also buried without natron or resinous treatments. As a generalizing trend, the treatment of male and female adult bodies at this lower social stratum is egalitarian, which parallels their tomb goods and other provisions for the afterlife.

The situation was markedly different for individuals from the wealthier, higher-status tombs in the Western Necropolis. Among the 18th–20th Dynasty individuals there, significant differences were based on age and sex (tombs with mixed contents from later periods are considered below). In the 18th Dynasty tomb 1159A, Sennefer has 14 layers of wrappings with a mask, while the accompanying female is poorly wrapped and consequently reduced to a skeleton.[49] From the same period in the tomb of Kha (tomb 8), the male owner is well wrapped and in much better condition than his wife Merit. According to Bruyère, none of these bodies shows the removal of the brain or organs, nor treatment with natron. In the Ramesside tomb 336 of Neferrenpet there were some 74 bodies, the majority of which show an incision in the stomach.[50] Some bodies were embalmed only with natron, others with resin. Sometimes the viscera were in natron and placed between the thighs. Bruyère recorded individuals with six to ten layers of wrappings for the most part.[51] In the tomb of Sennedjem (tomb 1), he recorded that the bodies were also poorly embalmed, suggesting that this was a widespread phenomenon even among the elite of the community. Although Egyptian bodily practices were an integral part of the burial process, other factors such as the tomb complex, its decoration, provision of tomb goods, and magico-ritual elements absorbed more time and expense in total.

In the Graeco-Roman period we generally witness a complete inversion of burial practices at Deir el Medina.[52] The external focus on display collapses into an exclusive focus on the presentation of the mummified body itself, particularly the elaboration of the linen wrappings and decoration. For example, linen wrappings in the New Kingdom are largely undecorated, whereas they become elaborately colored and decorated in later times. The painted shroud from tomb 1447, now in Leiden, is a pertinent example. These linens were very costly and, in Roman times, such burials should be regarded as expensive both in terms of materials and actual preparation. The Roman family buried in house C3 (tomb 1407) also had expensive painted funerary masks, such as those attached to the mummies of Pebos and Krates (fig. 8).[53] At Deir el Medina there is a significant shift from the mortuary constellation of the New

[46] For a fuller discussion of this question and the viability of the Deir el Medina data set, see L.M. Meskell, *Archaeologies of Social Life: Age, Class, Sex, etc., in Ancient Egypt* (Oxford, forthcoming).

[47] Bruyère (supra n. 3) 161–67.

[48] Bruyère (supra n. 3) 150–58, 170–72, 191.

[49] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1928): Deuxième partie* (Cairo 1929) 40–73.

[50] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1924–1925): Troisième partie* (Cairo 1926) 80–113.

[51] Bruyère (supra n. 50) 190–92.

[52] Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2).

[53] See Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2); see also the conclusions drawn in D. Montserrat, "Heron 'Bearer of *Philosophia* and Hermione *Grammatike*'," *JEA* 83 (1997) 224.

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Fig. 8. Mummy masks of Pebos and Krates (also known as Pebos) from house C3 (tomb 1407), Deir el Medina. (Photo courtesy Institut français d'archéologie orientale, Cairo)

Kingdom to the elevation of the body itself as the burial in microcosm. It was not simply a matter of expense or reduced outlay, but a shift in ideological focus. The body and representation of the individual became the repository of selfhood throughout the liminal phase between death and the afterlife.

Deir el Medina exemplifies salient trends in the treatment and elaboration of individual bodies. For example, the bodies of children from all socioeconomic levels were treated fairly minimally until the Graeco-Roman period, when heavy elaboration of the body is extended to all family members. Many infant bodies dating to the New Kingdom were poorly wrapped and reduced to skeletons. In terms of sex differentiation, the Eastern Necropolis illustrates an interesting pattern in terms of bodily wrappings and preparation of individuals. The 1300 series of tombs shows a fairly balanced treatment between the bodies of men, women, and adolescents, as evidenced by their layers of wrappings, jewelry, amulets, and by the absence of mummification. This situation parallels that of the tomb assemblages, which are generally equivalent at this level and different from those of the wealthier contemporaneous Western Necropolis.

In sum, we see a difference in bodily praxis in the 18th Dynasty on the basis of cemetery location and social level. Then we have marked diachronic change in bodily treatments from the 18th Dynasty to the Ramesside period, extending on to Greek and Roman times. To quote *in extenso* from Quirke:

> Mummification combines a physical preservation of the body, to keep it the same, with the anticipation of a spiritual afterlife, to transfigure the person and make him or her new and different, 'radiant'. Since the efforts to preserve a lifelike outer appearance can only be said to be partially successful, they were supplemented by plaster modelling of facial features and limbs in the third millennium and by packing the skin with stuffing in the early first millennium BC. The art of embalming reached its creative peak in Thebes in the eleventh and tenth centuries BC; in the Ptolemaic and Roman Periods stress was lain instead on the neat outer wrapping of the bandages, often concealing an alarming assortment of limbs within. . . . From c. 2000 BC the head might be covered with a mask made of linen layers stiffened with plaster, a papier mâché effect called cartonnage . . . and in the ninth to eighth centuries BC and again in the Ptolemaic Period the wooden coffin was replaced by a cartonnage case that entirely enclosed the mummy.[54]

[54] S. Quirke, *Ancient Egyptian Religion* (London 1992) 144.

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Treatments of the body such as mummification were not simply measures of preservation; rather, they transfigured the body and imbued it with magical qualities. Perishable bodily substances were replaced by eternal ones held within the mummy cover, which acted as a kind of magic garment.[55] The Egyptian term for mummy, *sʿḫ*, also means noble or dignitary and signifies the elevation of the deceased's status through the process of transfiguration. Evidence from the long time span of Deir el Medina, from the New Kingdom to the Graeco-Roman period, confirms Assmann's statement that the "mummy-case itself gradually evolved into increasingly lavishly decorated stucco-cartonnage and wooden anthropoid coffins, whereby pictorial motifs and decoration patterns merely represent an iconographic formulation of the exact same *akh*-sphere which is expressed in funerary literature by means of the spoken and written word."[56] From Ramesside times onward, the coffin itself was covered in texts such as excerpts from the underworld descriptions, and two important formulas from the Book of the Dead (Going out by Day and Opening the Tomb, and the formula for causing the *ba* to unite with the corpse in the underworld).[57] In the 21st Dynasty the decoration on wooden coffins reached its peak. It was also a period of experimentation, where the visual triumphs over the written word.[58] The increasing focus on the body, its preparation and transcendence, and its immediate covering (wrappings and coffin) reached its pinnacle in the Roman period, as evidenced by various burials at Deir el Medina such as the Roman family burial in house C3 (tomb 1407). This is a particularly rich burial of nine individuals: some of the bodies revealed gilding and even the child Sarapias had some 42 layers of linen wrapping and shrouds. With Roman Egypt we witness the last major revision of the funerary tradition, characterized by an increased focus on the representation of the individual and the individual body through portraiture and painted shrouds.

THE CONTINUING FOCUS ON DEATH AFTER THE NEW KINGDOM

For Deir el Medina it is possible to study how practices that developed in the Ramesside period were perpetuated and consolidated in later periods. Whereas many archaeological studies rely heavily on ethnographic analogies, Deir el Medina provides a unique opportunity to discuss later parallels that have a high degree of locational and cultural continuity. This new focus upon death and the body can be traced from the Ramesside period through the Late period to the Graeco-Roman era while still restricting the study to the spatial locus of Deir el Medina. The majority of the evidence comes from reused tomb structures at the site rather than newly constructed ones, since Deir el Medina had achieved symbolic significance as a locale. According to Baines and Lacovara, in Egypt as a whole "burial grounds or places in the necropolis became hallowed; people competed to build tombs or to be buried near them, increasing the crowding of the sites and the temptation to reuse earlier structures. The public and rich character of such mausoleums makes them a natural target for attack by those who do not share, or are indifferent to, the status and values of their builders."[59]

It is axiomatic that tombs and monuments were regularly pillaged, remodeled, and usurped throughout pharaonic history. Oddly, this widespread practice existed in a culture that supposedly revered, and feared, their dead. While plundering may have been infrequent within a single period (e.g., the 18th Dynasty) because descendants of the deceased were close at hand, it was more common between periods (e.g., Ptolemaic opening of New Kingdom tombs). At Deir el Medina, tomb reuse was generally confined to the Western Necropolis tombs and those to the north of the site, which represent the larger, more complex tombs from the site. The smaller, less prestigious tombs of the Eastern Necropolis were disregarded. They were inferior in terms of location, construction, size, and orientation. Given the substantial and complex nature of the reused tombs and later finds, it is worth briefly charting the archaeology of post-New Kingdom Deir el Medina.

Bruyère's focus during excavation was upon the site in the New Kingdom, yet he still recorded a significant amount of later material deposited in reused tombs in the Western Necropolis. As a result of his personal expertise and interest in the New Kingdom, it is likely that some of the post-Pharaonic material may have been overlooked or misclassified, a situation that might be rectified if one could recon-

[55] J. Assmann, "Death and Initiation in the Funerary Religion of Ancient Egypt," in Simpson (supra n. 37) 135–59.

[56] Assmann (supra n. 55) 139.

[57] Quirke (supra n. 30) 130.

[58] Quirke (supra n. 30) 145; J. Taylor, "Patterns of Colouring on Ancient Egyptian Coffins from the New Kingdom to the Twenty-sixth Dynasty," paper delivered at the conference "Colour and Painting in Ancient Egypt," British Museum, London (1996).

[59] Baines and Lacovara (supra n. 17).

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struct these tomb assemblages from the material housed in the Deir el Medina magazines. It is, however, still possible to derive some analyzable information from Bruyère's published reports. At least 75 tombs in the Western Necropolis contained notable later finds, and this figure might well be increased with more specialized study. There was a specific, and comparatively limited, range of post-New Kingdom finds: coffins, shabtis, and ceramics.[60] Unlike the abundant material from the 18th to 20th Dynasties, which illustrates the full spectrum of domestic, mortuary, and commemorative activities, the later finds primarily reflect the relative simplicity of burials in reused tombs. The post-New Kingdom tombs focus on elaborate coffins, whose decoration reached a peak of excellence at that time, as did the mummification of the bodies interred in them.[61] The quantity of material possibly relating to domestic functions was restricted to pottery, which may itself have been for funerary purposes. The sphere of death is paramount and this is reflected in the elaborate treatment of the body and coffin at the expense of the traditional concept of a burial assemblage. Even shabtis, typically common for the Third Intermediate period and Late period as the tomb artifact par excellence, diminished and eventually disappeared by Graeco-Roman times.

Later groups evidently felt the landscape of Deir el Medina to be sacred or potent, especially since the Western Necropolis was carpeted with small pyramids and other funerary superstructures. Such a mortuary vision must have been layered with meanings, though not necessarily coherent ones for the original New Kingdom occupants or their successors. It would be wrong to conflate these patterns of reuse as a practice related to the specificities of social memory. These practices were not exclusive to Deir el Medina: evidence from the Valley of the Nobles demonstrates extensive post-New Kingdom reuse of tombs.[62] Much of this activity might have been generated by the *choachytes*, the libation pourers of nearby Djeme, who were most active in the Ptolemaic period. They maintained the mortuary cult of the local people of Djeme, burying them in local tombs and providing regular cultic offerings.[63] Such activities brought them to Deir el Medina to reuse the numerous tombs at the deserted site. This explains the depositions of scores of anonymous bodies of this period. The nature and density of material supports the notion of significant patterns of later usage, which can be grouped into three types: scattered intrusive finds; domestic reuse of tombs (primarily in Late Antique times); and significant occupation and tomb remodeling.

The first category, scattered intrusive finds, generally consists of Graeco-Roman and Late Antique ceramics (tombs 1150, 1346, 1440, 1450, and 1451),[64] papyri (tomb 1446), shabtis (tombs 336 and 1006), decorated linen (tombs 330, 1060, 1447, and 1450), and isolated coffins (tombs 1022 and 1006). These individual finds are testimony to the type of individuals and practices present at Deir el Medina. For example, there is an unusual Roman coffin in 1022 illustrated by Bruyère, described as having leaf motifs and a bird-headed human figure in brown paint on a lime-washed base.[65] Several pieces of Late Antique cloth in tomb 1450 are also quite distinctive: one cloth with an indigo design dates to the third century A.D. and another with floral motifs from the fifth century A.D.[66]

The second category, domestic reuse of extant tombs, is especially noticeable in the Western Necropolis and around the temple of Hathor to the north of the site. This may relate to the proximity of the temple of Hathor as a potent ritual locale with funerary associations.[67] In the Western Necropolis tombs such as 1138 and 1233 were remodeled into structures resembling catacombs in the Late period and Ptolemaic period, respectively.[68] In the region of the temple, tomb 1438 demonstrates both Late Antique and Muslim-period alterations, while tomb 1437 was also reused by Christians, who replastered the walls white, decorated it with Coptic crosses, and altered the structure for occupation.[69] Tomb 1448 was filled

[60] Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2), esp. 185, chart.

[61] Baines (supra n. 33) 198.

[62] N. Strudwick, *The Tombs of Amenhotep, Khnummose, and Amenmose (TT294, 253, and 254)* (Oxford 1996); see also Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2).

[63] Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2) 182–83.

[64] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1948–1951): Première partie* (*FIFAO* 26, Cairo 1953).

[65] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1926): Troisième partie* (Cairo 1927) 10–13.

[66] Bruyère (supra n. 64) 92–96.

[67] Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2) 185–86.

[68] Tomb 1138: Bruyère (supra n. 49) 12–20; tomb 1233: B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1930): Troisième partie* (Cairo 1933) 30–31.

[69] Tomb 1438: B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1935–1940): Quatrième partie* (*FIFAO* 20.1, Cairo 1948) 110–11. In house SW5 of the village, once the dwelling of Khabekhenet, Bruyère discovered a bas-relief dating to the Christian period, suggesting that structural remains were still visible at the time. The fact that this find is unique, however, suggests that there was negligible Late Antique habitation in the enclosed village; see Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1934–1935): Troisième partie* (*FIFAO* 16, Cairo 1939) 327.

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with straw and water vessels, apparently having been reused in Late Antique times as a stable.[70] In tomb 1126 a potter's kiln was found, along with lamps and wine amphoras.[71] This set of structures to the north and east of the village seems to have been the most conducive to temporary reoccupation and habitation, in contrast to the houses within the enclosure. Although still small in scale, Late Antique occupation of the site was thus more domestic in character than any since the village was abandoned at the end of the New Kingdom. Though Late Antique material is found in many tombs, discrete burials were only discovered within the Christianized temple precinct, datable to the sixth or seventh century A.D. Bruyère recorded a total of nine elaborately wrapped bodies from this period, which he presumed to be monks. It is possible that other individuals were buried within the precinct walls, since Bruyère suggested that the Christian cemetery extended further to the northeast toward the temenos. Nonfunerary usage appears to have been low-density and concentrated around the temple, which remained the focal point of the site throughout the Graeco-Roman and Late Antique periods.

The third category of subsequent activity, high-density reuse and remodeling, is most telling in terms of levels of tomb reuse and reconstruction as well as burial practices. This last category is perhaps most pertinent to the decreasing focus upon the burial assemblage and increasing concentration on the body. Numerous tombs in the Western Necropolis housed great numbers of bodies dating from the Third Intermediate period to Graeco-Roman times; Christian burials do not seem to have been located in this part of the site. Bruyère did not record exact numbers of individuals, in part because of the great disturbance of the burials with consequential disarticulation of the bodies, but also because of his own lesser interest in the material. Moreover, anyone who has excavated tombs reused over a long period will appreciate the difficulties of making sense of the mass of debris. For example, tombs 1059, 1060, 1138, 1140, 1197, 1344A, and 1447 were recorded as containing Late-period individuals among the vestiges of earlier New Kingdom assemblages and human remains.[72] In the Ptolemaic period numerous bodies were deposited in tombs 1126, 1233, and 1346, and in later times into 1126, 1140, 1153, 1154, and 1155.[73] Datable Roman mummies appear in tombs 1332A and B and 1447, where there is a catacomb containing at least 60 Roman mummies, some with high-quality masks and shrouds, including a significant number of females and children.[74] Post-New Kingdom burials include increased numbers of women and children whose burials were generally closer in elaboration and expense to their male counterparts than was the case in earlier times. This trend began in the Ramesside period and culminated in Graeco-Roman times. The burials of children are particularly conspicuous since they were copiously wrapped and gilded, in as elaborate a manner as adults. There is no evidence of comparable treatment of children from New Kingdom Deir el Medina. This democratization of burial is significant.

None of the tombs used in the Graeco-Roman period appears to have been constructed at the time of deposition; this reuse of tombs with mixed tomb assemblages and bodies suggests a certain disregard for the actual context of the burial itself. In New Kingdom times, the integrity of the tomb had been crucial. The mortuary cult of the deceased was enacted at the site of the tomb, and this had serious implications in afterlife scenarios. Baines and Lacovara have referred to the mortuary practices of pharaonic Egypt as forming a "mausoleum culture";[75] given the powerful associations of the tomb, this description is very apt. Tombs were constructed largely during the tomb owners' lifetime and as such were very much part of life—the superstructure being a visible and tangible reminder of one's death and the hereafter. In principle, the tomb formed a concrete, yet liminal, installation for maintaining the deceased in life and where the worlds of the living and the dead overlap. The preservation of the deceased's mummified body, the grave goods, and the integrity of the tomb itself were fundamental. The associated mortuary chapel was the locus for the mortuary cult, which was integral to the maintenance of the deceased. Lastly, there were spells and curses to protect against the desecration of the tomb.

Yet the primacy of the tomb structure was soon overturned after the New Kingdom, and the integrity and elaboration of the body itself became central. The practice of placing coffins in among the disarray of previous occupations further supports this reading. The lack of substantive burial assemblages that characterizes post-New Kingdom mortuary praxis suggests that it was not the paraphernalia but the body itself that became the single focus after death. This shift in focus may have begun toward the end of

[70] B. Bruyère, *Rapport sur les fouilles de Deir el Médineh (1929): Deuxième partie* (Cairo 1930) 116–20.

[71] Bruyère (supra n. 65) 27–30.

[72] Tomb 1060: Bruyère (supra n. 65) 36–42; tomb 1140: Bruyère (supra n. 49) 12–20.

[73] Bruyère (supra n. 49) 29–33.

[74] Bruyère (supra n. 64) 104–10.

[75] Baines and Lacovara (supra n. 17).

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the New Kingdom, with the ever-dwindling array of associated tomb goods and a reduced concern for personalized tombs. This development is perhaps best illustrated by the elite Roman family burial, not in the Western Necropolis but in the New Kingdom settlement itself, in house C3.[76] Concern for the material structure and even the context of burial vanished. The materiality of death as well as its attendant material culture virtually disappeared, and the objectification of the body and bodily treatments took its place. As Baines and Lacovara remark, the mausoleum culture ultimately gave way to other concerns and modes of representation. From the emergence of the Egyptian state onward, "the preservation of the dead and their monuments was threatened by the passage of time and by competing concerns. By the end, it had become of relatively minor importance."[77]

CONCLUSIONS

A number of interrelated points concerning temporal change, social inequality, and the history of the body can be derived from this analysis. Deir el Medina provides Egyptian archaeology with a rare opportunity to investigate issues such as the body, death, and sacred landscapes within the confines of a coherent data set. This study of diachronic funerary practices can only be undertaken because later social groups revered the site of Deir el Medina, from the Third Intermediate period to Late Antique times. While I have argued that there were residual social memories in terms of death and burial, these were not always historically embedded. The meanings layered upon the site were thus multiple and contingent through time.

First, in terms of material culture and funerary practices, there is observable diachronic change. During the 18th Dynasty the construction of the person in death resembles that of the living. This gradually shifts to a focus upon death and the afterlife in Ramesside times. In the New Kingdom these trends are reflected in the material constructions (tombs, chapels, shrines, tomb goods), preparations (mummification), practices (domestic, mortuary, and commemorative rituals), and beliefs (about the individual, death, afterlife, and cosmology). In the 18th Dynasty the tomb (its construction, decoration, funerary assemblage, and treatment of individual bodies) is constituted around the concept of the living world and all its earthly associations. Following the Amarna period, 19th Dynasty burials focus on a constellation of features involving death and the afterlife. This is also mirrored in familial tombs, decoration, tomb goods, and especially bodily praxis itself. This elaborate scenario changes from the Third Intermediate period onward, culminating in Roman times.

Secondly, there is synchronic variability in terms of social inequality in death. In the 18th Dynasty substantial inequality existed in the burials of men, women, and children, with the former group taking priority in tomb wealth and burial expenditure. In the Western Necropolis difference is constituted around sex and, to a lesser degree, age. At the same time, for the less affluent individuals in the Eastern Necropolis, the major issue was age and perhaps marital status. So the primary social divide was really based upon wealth, which then splintered off into inequalities based on age or sex, depending on cemetery context. Intact 18th Dynasty tombs from the richer Western Necropolis suggest that as wealth and status increased, the relative wealth of wives or female partners declined significantly in the mortuary realm. In contrast, the situation for children appeared to be basically consistent across the social strata. The situation in the Ramesside period was markedly different. There is a move to generational tombs encompassing many individuals; while the visibility of women and children increases (hence the decline in Eastern Necropolis tombs), there is still a material discrepancy in favor of elite men and their male relatives. The increase in numbers of individuals present and the more favorable general treatment of women and children continue and peak in the Graeco-Roman period.

As I have argued elsewhere,[78] the concept of embodiment links the physical, social, and psychical aspects of the individual. In Egypt, the body in death assumed different positions in specific contexts: it was *subject* during living experience and also *object* in the sphere of death. In the mortuary context, social practices and technologies transformed the living body into an elaborated dead, yet deified body. The individual became closer to the godly pharaonic body, and closer to the gods themselves. The beautiful death, linking mortals to pharaohs and gods, became of pivotal importance and continued to be en-

[76] Montserrat and Meskell (supra n. 2) 188–93.

[77] Baines and Lacovara (supra n. 17).

[78] L.M. Meskell "The Somatisation of Archaeology: Institutions, Discourses, Corporeality," *Norwegian Archaeological Review* 29 (1996) 1–16; Meskell, "The Irresistible Body and the Seduction of Archaeology," in D. Montserrat ed., *Changing Bodies, Changing Meanings: Studies on the Human Body in Antiquity* (London 1998) 139–61.

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hanced, reaching its culmination in the hybrid culture of Graeco-Roman Egypt. In the latter period the cult of the body reached its apex, in life and death. Bodily practices, technologies, and ideologies become increasingly complex and articulated. The body has a long and fluid history at the site from the 18th Dynasty to Christian times, with a host of concomitant social ideologies woven around it. Concepts of the body changed radically and notions about individual bodies were linked to social axes of difference—age, sex, class, marital status, and wealth.

The data from Deir el Medina are also informative in terms of bodily histories. I suggest that our knowledge of Egyptian death and burial is in fact construed from Ramesside (if not Late-period) information and that the material paraphernalia of death only became common—though not universal—at this time. For example, wealthy 18th Dynasty individuals such as Kha and Merit, and Sennefer and Nefertiry, were not mummified in spite of their apparent wealth. Moreover, the funerals of neonates, children, and adolescents in the Eastern Necropolis may not have conformed to the same practices as adults, though the emotional outlay may have been significant. There is no single Egyptian mortuary practice, and this material challenges the seemingly homogeneous picture set out in the documentary record.

The experience of the Ramesside community was visibly different from that of the earlier 18th Dynasty community. They were a new population, some of whom had been alive through the Amarna upheaval, while others were indirectly affected by its aftermath. Assmann would propose that there were new sentiments about life, death, and piety, and more realizations about the contingencies of both worlds and the consequent fear of chaos.[79] Alternatively, Baines argues that those sentiments were always prevalent, and it was simply a matter of being more able to represent this as an individual in Ramesside times. We need to consider Baines's question: was it a matter of *reality* or *representation*? The Ramesside period is known as the age of personal piety, and the villagers were noticeably vigilant in their religious duties. As Baines notes, if the gods were neglected, they might abandon humanity as they supposedly had during the Amarna period.[80] Maintaining order was always fundamental in Egyptian culture and we can speculate that Ramesside people experienced tensions between the fear of chaos and instigating order. This may have translated into the bodily sphere. As a way of coping with contingency and controlling destiny, the body and the good death may have become central. People needed to perform elaborate rituals so that mortals could become gods in death, literally becoming an Osiris. This recognition must have had profound effects in the living sphere, prompting people to reflect on their life experiences, perhaps in a rather melancholic way. The experience of the Amarna period allowed all these aspects to be accommodated more fully in an ideological discourse, rather than being implicitly new phenomena. The people of Deir el Medina presumably oscillated between feelings of hedonism and fatalism—contradictory responses that were sometimes juxtaposed. Such moral uncertainties and worries were reflected in the New Kingdom Harper's songs[81] inscribed in private tombs: they combine skepticism, hedonism, and piety. They best sum up the contradictions of an ancient society that, to our eyes, appears to have been fascinated with death and the hereafter, but in reality was obsessed with sustaining life beyond the liminal boundaries of death.

> I have heard those songs that are in the tombs of old,
> What they tell in extolling life on earth,
> In belittling the land of the dead.
> Why is this done to the land of eternity,
> The right and just that has no terrors?[82]

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[79] Assmann (supra n. 37).

[80] Baines (supra n. 33) 127.

[81] R.B. Parkinson, "Egyptian Literature and the Decorum of Doubt," paper delivered at Yale University, New Haven (1995).

[82] This translation of the New Kingdom text has been taken from M. Lichtheim, *Ancient Egyptian Literature* 2: *The New Kingdom* (Berkeley 1976) 115–16.

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